

PROMISING ATTRIBUTES AND EXPERIENCES

Attitudinal Responses to Functional Versus Experiential Ad Claims and the Moderating Role of Involvement

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ABSTRACT: Advertisers face several message options when they position a new brand in well-established categories. Functional benefit claims versus experiential claims represent two options. Functional claims focus on tangible attributes and benefits, whereas experiential claims focus on promises of experiences the consumer should expect from the new brand. In this paper, we present the results from two experiments testing the persuasiveness of ads promising experience versus the persuasiveness of ads promising functional benefits of a new entrant. In the first experiment, we found that involvement moderates the effect of claim type on attitude toward a new category entrant in retail banking. This finding was replicated and extended in a second experiment using ski resorts as the context. Our findings suggest that functional benefit claims outperform experiential claims in high-involvement situations and that the strength of message arguments can be just as important as the framing choice. The research also shows that the two advertising claim types elicit different cognitive responses: functional claims trigger mostly semantic memory, whereas experiential claims trigger more episodic memories.

When searching for the Holy Grail—or the differentiated position in consumers' minds—marketers pursue different positioning strategies. Advertising agencies often proclaim the superiority of messages with an experiential content, as consumers supposedly are overexposed to attribute-oriented, functional messages. With experiential messages, advertisers hope to evoke autobiographical memories to influence consumers' evaluations of brands (e.g., Baumgartner, Sujan, and Bettman 1992; Braun-LaTour et al. 2004; Price, Axom, and Coupey 1997; Sujan, Bettman, and Baumgartner 1993). As Pine and Gilmore proclaim, “as goods and services become commoditized, the customer experiences that companies create will matter most” (Pine and Gilmore 1998, p. 97). However appealing this simple contention, the relative persuasiveness of experiential framing compared with functional benefit framing in advertising claims for new entrants into established product or service categories cannot be discerned from previous research. That is, the entrant faces (at least) two challenges with a trade-off dilemma: first, to become recognized as a credible actor in the category, and second, to be differentiated enough to be perceived as a better alternative. The first challenge requires a need to satisfy important (semantic) category as-

sociations, often labeled points-of-parity (Keller 2008; Keller, Sternthal, and Tybout 2002), whereas the second challenge encourages persuasive stimuli that make connections between the new entrant and consumers' own lives in order for the new entrant to be perceived as personally relevant (Baumgartner, Sujan, and Bettman 1992; Krugman 1967; Sujan, Bettman, and Baumgartner 1993).

This paper's purpose is to advance previous research on the effects of persuasive stimuli triggering autobiographical memory (promising experience) by comparing such effects with those of stimuli triggering prototypical category associations (promising functional benefits). In addition, instead of relying on the suggested personal relevance (involvement) of autobiographically oriented messages (e.g., Baumgartner, Sujan, and Bettman 1992), we explicitly seek to control for situational involvement. The paper is organized as follows: First we provide the theoretical background on claim types and involvement. Then we report Study 1, with situational involvement manipulated following the procedure outlined in Petty, Cacioppo, and Schumann (1983). Ad-claim type is manipulated with one ad emphasizing promises of experiences versus another emphasizing functional brand benefits from a new retail bank. Study 2 follows, in which we extend and replicate Study 1 in another category (ski resorts), promising different experiences and benefits. In addition, we manipulate argument

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quality by introducing both strong and weak versions of the two ad-claim types. Argument quality manipulations allow for better understanding of the cognitive processes that could be working differently under high versus low involvement. Lastly, we assess cognitive processing by including a thought-listing protocol. Discussion and limitations are addressed in the paper's final section.

THEORY

An important task of advertising is to provide consumers information they find relevant in determining the brand's true merits. In this paper, we make a distinction between functionally benefit framed (USP) and experientially framed advertising claims. According to the USP school of advertising, dollars should be put into brand-benefit oriented advertising claims (e.g., classic Unilever and P&G positioning strategies), emphasizing the superiority of salient attributes and their consequences in line with expectancy-value models of beliefs and attitudes (Fishbein and Ajzen 1975). If we trust experience economy evangelists, however, consumers care less for the benefit-based approach in the experience-based "dream society" (Jensen 1999; Pine and Gilmore 1998). Consequently, they are not persuaded by ads with USP-inspired claims either. This normative point of view doesn't seem to be shared by advertising practitioners and is often contradicted in observed consumer behavior. Many advertising claims encountered every day are functional, trying to convey information about the superiority of brand-related attributes and benefits. We argue that what is deemed most persuasive depends on the recipient's perception of the brand's personal relevance. In other words, we expect that the effects of functional benefit versus experiential ad claims will be moderated by the recipients' level of situational involvement.

Experiential Versus Functional Benefit Ad Claims

Advertisers frequently utilize consumers' episodic memories in order to cause consumers to imagine future experiences when reading their ad claims (Escalas and Luce 2004). People tend to selectively remember past events and encounters in the product category (Braun-Latour et al. 2004) in shaping their expectations created by the ad consistent with classic schema-based thought (e.g., Bartlett 1932). These memories of experiences with brands are formed through the course of repeated interactions between the brand and the individual (e.g., Holbrook and Hirschman 1982), giving rise to potentially idiosyncratic representations in both episodic (personally experienced, autobiographical) and semantic (general facts) memory (Baumgartner et al. 1992; Tulving 1972, 2002). Broadly speaking, episodic memory is memory of information

related to the self (Brewer 1986) and memory of events from one's own life (Neisser 1988). Hence, episodic memory has also been referred to as *personal memory* (Brewer 1986) and *autobiographical memory* (Baumgartner, Sujaan, and Bettman 1992). In general, for a given product or service category, existing customers will have memories of experiences in the category, and these personal experiences tend to be personally relevant. According to Krugman (1967), the assessment of memories connected to personal experiences will enhance involvement in the message. It is therefore likely that ads focusing on experiences will activate episodic memories of experiences with brands in the relevant category. These memories cannot necessarily be assigned to a specific time or place, but will still be experienced as unique encounters (Baumgartner, Sujaan, and Bettman 1992). When consumers activate episodic memory, they tend to focus on personal experiences—the experience anticipated with the brand—rather than benefits from the brand itself (MacInnis and Jaworski 1989; Percy and Elliot 2005, pp. 202–205). The consumers will think fewer brand-benefit thoughts and recall less relevant brand features, since autobiographical memories will distract their attention away from the semantic memory-based benefits (e.g., Sujaan 1985). As Baumgartner, Sujaan, and Bettman put it: "When autobiographical memories are accessed, individuals' thoughts are likely to reflect fewer cognitions about the product's features, such as how the product rates on various attributes and the importance of these attributes" (1992, p. 58).

However, whereas autobiographical memories might include references to incumbent brands, and hence their credibility as category members, new entrants cannot expect the same leverage from these types of memories. The new entrant has to satisfy category points-of-parity associations to be categorized as a credible category member (Keller 2008). Hence, it becomes crucial for the new entrant to learn how different types of information are used in the initial categorization and judgment processes. Drawing on Lynch, Marmorstein, and Weigold (1988) and Lynch (2006), this can be a question of diagnosticity, for example, which information is most relevant to reach a judgment of an entrant: information about brand benefits or promises about experiences? The consumers' subjective decision goals will certainly influence which type of input is evaluated more diagnostically; however, previous research has shown that the diagnosticity depends on whether the consumer can discriminate between alternatives in the choice situation (e.g., Lynch, Marmorstein, and Weigold 1988). In situations in which a new entrant is presented, consumers must evaluate the entrant relative to established brands in the category. If the new entrant is accompanied by functional benefits advertising claims, the comparison task is relatively straightforward, matching the ad's information with semantic facts-based knowledge about the prototypical attributes and benefits in the category (e.g., Rosch 1978).

Experiential advertising claims, on the other hand, are harder to compare, since the consumers' episodic memories of past experiences are not directly comparable with information about future experiences expected from the new entrant. In addition, the activated experiences will vary across the consumer sample, since autobiographical memories shaping expectations of future experiences with the brand are defined as being unique to each consumer. With higher variance, it is less likely that the limited number of experiences or their framed content in the advertisement will match experiences accessible to the consumer at the time of exposure. That could imply reduced diagnosticity for such claims.

Compared with experiential claims, functional benefit claims are likely to face less variation in the target segment's comparison standard, simply because the brand-related information opens up for relatively less idiosyncratic interpretations, is more familiar to most recipients, and is potentially more easily encoded. In addition, benefit claims are more easily compared to the salient category points-of-parity benefits (Keller, Sternthal, and Tybout 2002). Consequently, it is more likely that the new brand's features will match important category features, thereby being perceived as more diagnostic in consumer's evaluation of the new entrant. Experiential advertising claims are likely to activate episodic memory. According to Baumgartner, Sujan, and Bettman (1992), consumers' evaluations will shift from an analytic review of attributes and benefits contained in the product information, and a category-based comparison, to expectations of future experiences based on feelings and memories of past encounters in the product category—still at the category level. We agree with Baumgartner, Sujan, and Bettman (1992) and Sujan, Bettman, and Baumgartner (1993) that the experiential claims might have high potential for being perceived as relevant in forming a judgment. But as no real experiences exist for the new brand, incumbent brands (Muthukrishnan 1995) will profit more from this aspect of autobiographical memories, since the consumers can imagine more future experiences with these brands. Hence, the likelihood of lower experience matching and lower relevance of entrant-anchored experiences in the entrant's claim might produce a less positive attitude than a functional benefit claim from the same entrant.

Involvement and Ad-Claim Type

Previous studies of ad claims with experiential focus (e.g., Baumgartner, Sujan, and Bettman 1992; Price, Axom, and Coupey 1997; Sujan, Bettman, and Baumgartner 1993) have found that the persuasiveness of such claims tend to interact with the recipient's level of self-referencing, a dispositional tendency to relate new information to past experiences. This can be conceptualized as a tendency to become more involved in issues one can relate to one's self, and consequently, one's

experiences. Generally, with increasing levels of involvement, recipients of persuasive messages should elaborate more extensively on the available information in order to reach a judgment (Petty and Cacioppo 1986; Putrevu 2008). Self-referencing would tend to be logically tied to experiential claims (i.e., bias processing in the direction of one's own experience, or bias judgments in favor of one's own experiences [Petty and Cacioppo 1986]). Situational involvement, on the other hand, could just as well increase relatively objective processing when elaboration likelihood is not constrained to be very high or low (Petty and Cacioppo 1986; Petty and Wegener 1999). Moreover, it is in the advertiser's interest to be able to utilize situational cues to increase the personal relevance of advertising messages. We suggest that involvement will affect what type of ad claims the recipient perceives as more or less relevant in order to assess the true merits of the new brand.

Essentially, we propose that the recipient's level of involvement will moderate the effect of claim type on attitude toward the new brand, suggesting an interaction between ad-claim type and level of involvement on brand attitudes for the new entrant. In high-involvement conditions, a new entrant using functional benefits-based advertising claims should most likely be compared with the prototypical points-of-parity of the category (Keller 2008). Consumers would have fewer references to established brands and more references to category-specific associations when evaluating the entrant. If the functional benefits were evaluated favorably, the matching process should produce a positive attitudinal response. As no real experiences would exist for the new entrant (only for incumbent brands and the product category in general) (e.g., Muthukrishnan 1995), an experiential claim from a new entrant could be regarded as less persuasive when the consumer scrutinizes the message in order to reach a judgment. In addition, the experiential claim is more likely than the functional benefit claim to be compared with brand-specific rather than category-specific associations, as the consumer's own experiences with existing brands would serve as the natural comparison norm. Hence:

H1: There will be a two-way interaction between type of advertising claim and level of involvement. More specifically, in high-involvement conditions, functional advertising claims will produce more favorable attitudes to the new brand than will experiential advertising claims. Under low involvement, there will be only minor differences in attitudinal responses across type of advertising claims.

STUDY 1

The purpose of Study 1 was to test the predictions that functional ad claims outperform experiential claims for new entrants in high-involvement conditions, and that the difference would be minimal under low involvement. Basically,

Study 1 employed a 2 (ad claim: experiential versus functional benefits) $\times$ 2 (involvement: high versus low) between-subjects factorial design. Retail banking was chosen as the setting for Study 1. In recent years, several Internet-only retail banks have been launched in Norway where the study took place, and therefore, a launch of a new entrant could be perceived as a likely event. Furthermore, well-established banks have recently run ad campaigns in which a long company history is used as a proof-point to substantiate promises of experiences. Thus, the use of experiential ad claims was not expected to appear unusual or irrelevant to the respondents. In addition, we needed a category that was highly familiar to the participants.

Participants and Procedures

In Study 1, 148 undergraduate business students served as participants. They were recruited from two classes; all participated voluntarily. They participated in groups of up to 15 students in a large lecture hall. On arrival, the students were told that they should evaluate a new business concept, an Internet-only bank targeting the student segment. They were given one booklet with the manipulations, stimuli, and measures. First, they provided information about their current bank relationship: name of bank, length of customer relationship, how many banks they currently used, and finally, they rated their attitudes toward their current bank. The first part of the booklet served as a prime for both semantic and episodic memory of retail banking. Then they were exposed to the advertisement for the fictitious Student Bank in one of two versions, either with experiential claims, or benefit-oriented claims. Details about these ads will be described in the next section. Following ad exposure, they rated their attitudes toward the bank and the ad, and their likelihood of switching to this bank. Finally, they provided their age and gender.

Manipulations and Measurements

Two advertisements were developed, equal in all respects except their textual content. The headline in the experiential claim said, "You will experience . . .," whereas the headline in the benefit claim said, "We promise to deliver . . ." Below the headline, we presented information highlighting either the functional benefits of the bank or future positive experiences. To make the ads similar in all aspects other than functional benefit versus experiential framing, we used the same three brand attributes in both ads. Specifically, the framing was varied in the two ad versions both through the headline of the ads, and through the wording of the three claim elements. Pretests were conducted to ensure that the two claim types were perceived as equally strong. Forty-eight students (different from those participating in the main experiment) participated voluntarily in the pretest. They were randomly divided into

two groups, and these groups rated the perceived cogency of the arguments in either the experiential or the functional benefit version of the advertisement. A one-way analysis of variance (ANOVA) on perceived argument strength indicated that the ads were perceived as equally strong, $M_{\text{experiential}} = 3.4$ versus $M_{\text{functional}} = 3.44$, $F(1, 47) = .008$, *n.s.* (not significant).

We manipulated the involvement following the procedure outlined by Petty, Cacioppo, and Schumann (1983). In the experiment booklet, two versions of the cover story were prepared to make the new bank appear higher or lower in personal relevance. In the high-involvement condition, the cover story headline read, "In April 2007 we launch the Student Bank." In addition, we added a few sentences arguing that the new bank would devote its efforts to being the best bank for them as students, focusing on their special needs. In the low-involvement condition, the headline read, "In 2009, at latest, we launch the Student Bank." In addition, we added a sentence arguing that the new bank probably would focus only on students.

The dependent measure, brand attitude, was measured with three, seven-point semantic differential scales with instructions and scale anchors: "To what extent did you find the brand . . . bad/good, negative/positive, unfavorable/favorable" (see, e.g., Haugtvedt and Petty 1992).

Results

Manipulation Checks

Following Petty, Cacioppo, and Schumann (1983, p. 141), one question assessed perceived argument quality (with the wording "please rate your assessment of the quality of the message content on the scale below") on a seven-point semantic differential scale with anchors 1 = bad, 7 = good. A one-way ANOVA on this measure with ad type as between-subject factor indicated that the benefit-oriented claim was not significantly stronger than the experiential claim, $M_{\text{experiential}} = 3.84$ versus $M_{\text{functional}} = 4.14$, $F(1, 146) = 1.59$, *n.s.* A second question assessed perceived personal relevance of the Student Bank on a seven-point semantic differential scale with the introduction "In total, I perceive the Student Bank as" with scale anchors 1 = of low relevance, and 7 = of high relevance. A one-way ANOVA on this measure with involvement as between-subject factor indicated that the high-involvement participants rated the bank as more relevant than low-involvement participants did, $M_{\text{high involvement}} = 4.04$ versus $M_{\text{low involvement}} = 3.49$, $F(1, 146) = 4.69$, $p < .05$.

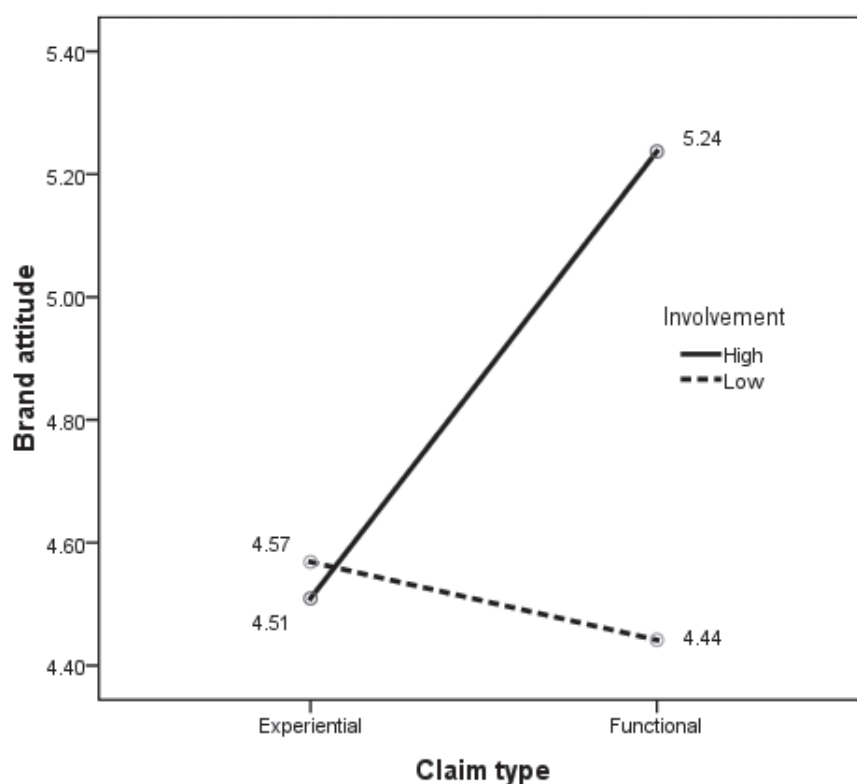
Test of Hypothesis 1

The three brand attitude items were all highly interrelated (Cronbach's $\alpha = .91$). They were thus collapsed into an aver-

TABLE 1
Study I: Brand Attitude Scores

	Low involvement		High involvement	
	Mean	SD (n)	Mean	SD (n)
Claim type				
Experience	4.57	1.13 (34)	4.51	1.34 (36)
Functional	4.44	1.17 (40)	5.24	1.18 (38)

FIGURE 1
Claim Type × Involvement Interaction on Brand Attitude



age index. A 2 (ad claim) × 2 (involvement) between-subjects ANOVA on the brand attitude index produced the following results (see Table 1 and Figure 1): There was no main effect of ad-claim type, $F(1, 144) = 2.28$, *n.s.* The result indicates that a functional claim is not invariably more compelling or stronger than an experiential claim even for a new entrant. The main effect of involvement, $F(1, 144) = 3.42$, $p = .067$, approached significance, and showed that participants tended to rate the brand more favorably in high- compared with low-involvement conditions, $M_{\text{high involvement}} = 4.87$ versus $M_{\text{low involvement}} = 4.51$. However, the interaction between ad claim and involvement was the primary prediction of H1. Overall, the interaction was significant, $F(1, 144) = 4.61$, $p = .033$, indicating that high-involvement participants responded more favorably to functional than experiential claims, whereas

low-involvement participants were indifferent to claim type. Planned contrasts suggest that the attitude toward Student Bank was equal across claim types under low involvement, $M_{\text{functional}} = 4.44$ versus $M_{\text{experiential}} = 4.57$, $F(1, 144) = .31$, *n.s.*, but significantly different from response to claim types in the high-involvement conditions, $M_{\text{functional}} = 5.24$ versus $M_{\text{experiential}} = 4.51$, $F(1, 144) = 6.89$, $p < .01$. In total, the results support H1. Table 1 shows cell means, number of participants per cell. Figure 1 displays the ad-claim type by involvement interaction.

Discussion

The results of our first study suggest that the choice of ad-claim profile can make a substantial difference in influencing

attitudes toward new entrants, especially under higher levels of situational involvement. As hypothesized, we obtained support for an ad-claim type by involvement interaction on brand attitude. Participants in the high-involvement condition responded more favorably to functional than to experiential claims, whereas participants in the low-involvement condition were indifferent to claim type. As the ads were similar in all aspects except the framing of the textual content of the advertising claims (i.e., similar attributes addressed in both versions, information perceived as equally cogent in both versions), there is no obvious reason why one claim type should be less persuasive than the other. This indicates that functional claims are more important for new entrants in establishing connections to relevant points-of-parity association in the category. For low-involvement participants, however, the type of ad claim did not seem to matter for the evaluation.

A core assumption in the persuasion literature is that attitudes can be formed as a result of different cognitive processes on a continuum from almost no cognitive processing to very effortful thinking (Petty and Cacioppo 1986; Petty and Wegener 1999). This dual-process perspective suggests that in some situations an attitude can be formed based on careful scrutiny of message arguments, whereas in other situations, attitudes may arise based on simple inferential processes. Message or issue involvement and accompanying message scrutiny, are a result of both ability and motivation to process the information. We manipulated personal relevance to situationally induce high- and low-involvement conditions in Study 1. In the high-involvement condition, participants probably used the information provided in the ads and compared them with semantic knowledge of the bank category. The participants in the high-involvement condition used the arguments in the functional claim to form attitudes. Participants in the high-involvement condition who were exposed to the experiential claim also elaborated on the content of the ad, but since the provided information could not be compared to their semantic knowledge of the bank category or their personal experiences with an established brand, the ad did not evoke any emotions or beliefs from which to shape an attitude (Baumgartner, Suja, and Bettman 1992). The resulting judgment of the brand was neutral and comparable to the evaluation made by participants in the low-involvement condition.

The results of Study 1 show support for our prediction that functional claims outperform experiential claims under situational high involvement. Study 1 does not provide compelling evidence of the underlying cognitive processes explaining these results, however. Manipulation of argument quality could allow for better understanding of the cognitive processes that work differently under high- versus low-involvement conditions (e.g., Petty, Cacioppo, and Schumann 1983). Although we controlled for argument quality differences between functional versus experiential claims through pretests and measurements

in Study 1, a second experiment that (a) explicitly manipulated argument quality to ensure that responses to different ad-claim types were not simply due to inherent differences in cogency of these claims, (b) incorporated measures of cognitive responses given to the claims to look for evidence that the different claims really tapped into different memory structures, and (c) replicated the interaction from Study 1 in a different product or service context would increase our confidence in the results from the first study. Study 2 was conducted to address these three issues.

STUDY 2

The overall purpose of Study 2 was to replicate and extend the findings of Study 1, that is, we still wanted to test the effect of functional versus experiential ad claims, and the moderating role of involvement. Study 2 employed a 2 (ad claim: experiential versus functional benefits) $\times$ 2 (argument quality: strong versus weak) $\times$ 2 (involvement: high versus low) between-subjects factorial design. A fictional new ski resort in the Alps was chosen as the setting for Study 2. Whereas retail banking (context for Study 1) could be said to be rather functional by nature ("it all boils down to interest rates or money"), ski resorts can be said to offer a more credible mix of both functional benefits (number of slopes and lifts), and experiences (altitude, after-ski, dining, shopping, etc.). The number of foreign ski destinations marketed in Norway is continuously increasing, in the sense that travel agencies and companies make them available through direct flights, bus packages, and so forth. In other words, a ski resort can be of old age and well established, but new for the target market in question. Consequently, this choice of context should put our main hypothesis to a stronger test. The choice of a different product category and different experiences/benefits compared to those in Study 1 could also be seen as a means to strengthen external validity.

In addition, to gauge the underlying processes that help to explain the results, Study 2 included a thought-listing procedure in order to control that the stimuli influenced both the amount and content of cognitive responses.

Finally, Study 2 also introduced an argument quality manipulation as an experimental technique to uncover cognitive processing. The logic behind the argument quality manipulation is purely methodological. The assumption based on the elaboration likelihood model (ELM) tradition (e.g., Petty, Cacioppo, and Schumann 1983; Petty and Wegener 1999) is that sensitivity to the cogency or quality of information in persuasive messages (advertisements) should be different under varying degrees of elaboration likelihood. As elaboration likelihood is assumed to increase with higher levels of involvement or perceived personal relevance of the advertising message, participants in high-involvement conditions should be more sus-

ceptible to variation in argument quality than are participants with lower involvement. This greater susceptibility should be evident through both the amount of cognitive responses given and the attitudinal responses given to the advertising claim. Brands with functional claims are more easily compared to semantic category memory than brands with experiential claims, and these functional-claim brands are therefore more credible as new category members. Hence, in high-involvement conditions, functional claims backed by strong arguments should be more persuasive than equally strong experiential claims. In low-involvement conditions, the consumer will elaborate less extensively on available information, including the quality of the arguments. These assumptions would essentially mean that we should have results similar to those of Study 1 for low-involvement participants (i.e., no attitudinal differences across claim types). For high-involvement participants, we should obtain an interaction between argument quality and claim type. Formally, these assumptions present the following hypotheses to be tested in Study 2:

H2: There will be a three-way interaction between claim type, involvement, and argument quality on attitude toward the new brand. This interaction will manifest itself through a two-way interaction between claim type and argument quality under high involvement where functional claims should be more sensitive to variation in argument quality than are experiential claims, and strong functional claims should be most persuasive. In low-involvement conditions, we would expect no interaction between claim type and argument quality, and no differences in persuasiveness between claim types.

H3: There will be a higher number of experience (functional)-oriented cognitive responses than functional (experience)-oriented cognitive responses in experiential (functional) ad-claim conditions.

H4: There will be a higher total number of cognitive responses under high- than low-involvement conditions.

Participants and Procedure

There were 220 undergraduate business students who served as participants in Study 2. They were recruited from an introductory marketing management class; all participated voluntarily. They participated in groups of up to 30 students in a large lecture hall. On arrival, the students were told that they would evaluate a new ski resort in the Alps. They were given one booklet with the manipulations, stimuli, and measures. These will be described in more detail in the next section. First, they were required to read an instruction text that also contained the involvement manipulation. Second, they were exposed to an advertisement for the “Bad Holzgau ski resort,” which was being marketed for the first time in Norway. The ads dif-

fered according to the experimental conditions and came in four different versions. Each participant was exposed to only one version: strong experiential, weak experiential, strong functional, or weak functional. The ads will be described in more detail in the next section. Following ad exposure, they rated their attitudes toward the ski resort, their likelihood of traveling to it, their attitudes toward the ad, and provided measures of the strength of the arguments in the ad. Third, the participants completed a thought-listing procedure. They were required to list all thoughts that came to mind during their exposure to the ad, one thought per line on a page, and were instructed not to flip back to the ad. Fourth, they provided responses to manipulations checks of experiential versus functional benefits orientation in the ad and their involvement in reading the ad. Subsequent to these measures, they stated their age and gender, and described their general experience in skiing and how often they went to ski resorts.

Manipulations and Measurements

We developed four advertisements that were equal in all respects except their textual content. Pictorial background, font type and size, and amount of information were thus controlled for. The headline in the experiential claim said, “Do you remember your last ski vacation?” The headline in the functional claim said, “A good ski vacation offer.” Below the headline, the experiential claim continued by urging the reader to “Think about a holiday experience where you . . .,” followed by three bullet points with either weak or strong attribute information. In the functional claim version, the same attribute information was used, but it was introduced by the line “We offer you the following benefits: . . .” To make the ads similar in all aspects other than the functional benefit versus experiential textual content, we used the same three brand attributes in both ads (number of slopes, after-ski event, and restaurants). Strong and weak versions of the claims were manipulated by varying the level of the claim cogency (see, e.g., Coulter and Punj 2004, p. 56). For example, “The Alps’ largest number of slopes” (strong) versus “A small number of slopes, but easy to use” (weak). These four versions were subject to a pretest to ensure that the strong (weak) versions of the claims were perceived as equally strong (weak) across claim type. In a pretest of the stimuli, 184 students from the same subject pool as that used in the main experiment participated. They rated one ad each on three, seven-point (1–7) semantic differential scales with instructions and scale anchors: “I found the message in the advertisement to be . . . very unconvincing/very convincing, bad/good, weak/strong. The three items were highly interrelated (Cronbach’s $\alpha = .895$) and were collapsed into an average index. Planned contrasts within each level of argument strength on this index showed no significant differences between claim types. For the strong arguments,

the results were $M_{\text{strong functional}} = 3.93$, $M_{\text{strong experiential}} = 3.89$, $F(1, 175) = .09$, *n.s.* For the weak arguments, the results were $M_{\text{weak functional}} = 3.10$, $M_{\text{weak experiential}} = 3.24$, $F(1, 175) = .36$, *n.s.* The crucial goal of the pretest was to obtain equal strength perceptions across claim types, and these results indicated that the manipulations were perceived as intended. The ads were tested, independent of the involvement manipulation, to get as clean results as possible in the pretest. In the subsequent main experiment, the cogency attached to the messages could also be somewhat influenced by the preceding involvement manipulation, but at this point, we found at least an indication that argument quality varied independently of claim type.

We manipulated situational involvement following the procedure, as we did in Study 1, outlined by Petty, Cacioppo, and Schumann (1983). In the experiment booklet, two versions of the cover story were prepared to make the newly marketed ski resort appear higher or lower in personal relevance. In the high-involvement condition, the cover story read, "In 2009/2010 the new ski resort targets young ski enthusiasts from your country and students are especially welcome as guests." In addition, we added a sentence promising better price deals for students. In the low-involvement condition, the cover story read: "The new ski resort will be offered to the family segment in your country in 2010/2011 at the earliest. For the moment they target the central European market."

The dependent variable, brand attitude, was measured with three, seven-point semantic differential scales with instructions and scale anchors: "To what extent did you find Bad Holzgau . . . bad/good, negative/positive, unfavorable/favorable" (see, e.g., Haugtvedt and Petty 1992).

Results

Manipulation Checks

Participants rated their level of felt involvement on two semantic differential scales: "I perceived the advertisement as: irrelevant (1) versus very relevant (7)," and "I found Bad Holzgau to be: irrelevant to me (1) to very relevant to me (7)." These two items were highly correlated, and hence collapsed into an average index. A one-way ANOVA on this index showed that participants in the high-involvement condition found the advertisement significantly more relevant than did the low-involvement participants, $M_{\text{high involvement}} = 3.79$ versus $M_{\text{low involvement}} = 3.34$, $F(1, 218) = 6.85$, $p = .01$. Following the procedure suggested by Petty, Cacioppo, and Schumann (1983, p. 141), perceived argument quality was assessed using three semantic differential scales: "I found the arguments in the advertisement for Bad Holzgau to be: little convincing (1) to highly convincing (7), bad (1) to good (7), and weak (1) to strong (7)." These three items were highly interrelated, and were therefore collapsed into an average index (Cronbach's

$\alpha = .91$). A one-way ANOVA on this index showed that participants in the strong-arguments condition found the arguments to be significantly stronger than the participants in the weak-arguments condition, $M_{\text{strong arguments}} = 3.99$ versus $M_{\text{weak arguments}} = 3.14$, $F(1, 217) = 23.67$, $p < .001$. Study 2 contained cognitive responses providing the opportunity to test whether participants in the strong-arguments condition generated relatively more positive than negative cognitive responses compared with participants in the weak-arguments condition. We used a difference score (positive minus negative cognitive responses) as a dependent variable in a one-way ANOVA with argument strength as grouping factor. This analysis showed that participants in the strong-arguments condition had more positive than negative cognitive responses compared with weak argument condition participants, $M_{\text{strong}} = .233$ versus $M_{\text{weak}} = -.60$, $F(1, 208) = 16.25$, $p < .001$.

Finally, we analyzed participants' responses to two statements to assess the extent to which the participants perceived the claim profile of the advertisements as intended. The statements were: "Bad Holzgau makes promises about: benefits at the resort (1) to experiences at the resort (7)," and "The draft of the advertisement for Bad Holzgau made me think of: benefits of different ski resorts (1) to experiences with my own skiing vacations (7)." Responses were collapsed into an average index. A one-way ANOVA on this index showed that respondents to the functional ad claim scored significantly lower, indicating that they had a stronger perception of functionality than the respondents in the experiential ad-claim condition, $M_{\text{functional}} = 3.39$ versus $M_{\text{experiential}} = 4.05$, $F(1, 211) = 13.37$, $p < .001$. Taken together, these results indicated that our manipulations had worked as intended. We should also note that the test for the profile of cognitive responses (H3), if supported, also would lend support to our ability to trigger different memory categories in response to the different ad-claim types.

Tests of Hypotheses

The second hypothesis predicted a three-way interaction between ad-claim type, argument quality, and involvement on attitude toward the new brand. The dependent variable was constructed by forming an averaged scale from the three highly interrelated brand attitude items (Cronbach's $\alpha = .847$). This scale served as the dependent variable in a 2 (ad claim: experiential versus functional benefits) $\times$ 2 (argument quality: strong versus weak) $\times$ 2 (involvement: high versus low) between-subjects ANOVA. The following results were obtained (see Table 2 and Figure 2a and 2b). First, there was a significant main effect of involvement, with more positive brand attitudes in the high- versus low-involvement condition, $M_{\text{high involvement}} = 4.50$ versus $M_{\text{low involvement}} = 4.26$, $F(1, 220) = 4.62$, $p < .05$. Second, the main effect of argument quality was also significant,

TABLE 2
Study 2: Brand Attitude Scores

	Low involvement		High involvement	
	Mean	SD (n)	Mean	SD (n)
Strong arguments				
Claim type				
Experience	4.60	1.00 (31)	4.50	.92 (30)
Functional	4.49	1.17 (24)	5.24	.99 (28)
Weak arguments				
Claim type				
Experience	3.87	1.09 (31)	4.27	.78 (25)
Functional	3.91	.70 (25)	4.01	1.15 (26)

with more positive brand attitude in response to strong versus weak arguments in general, $M_{\text{strong arguments}} = 4.71$ versus $M_{\text{weak arguments}} = 4.01$, $F(1, 220) = 26.68$, $p < .001$. There was no main effect of claim type; participants responded equally well to both advertising claims in general, $M_{\text{functional}} = 4.41$ versus $M_{\text{experiential}} = 4.31$, $F(1, 220) = < 1$, *n.s.* None of the three two-way interactions approached significance. However, the important prediction of H2 was a three-way interaction qualifying the preceding significant main effects. The three-way interaction was significant, $F(1, 220) = 4.56$, $p < .05$. Follow-up analyses showed that, as predicted, there was a significant interaction between claim type and argument quality in the high-involvement condition, $F(1, 105) = 7.08$, $p < .01$, accompanied by a significant main effect of argument strength, $F(1, 105) = 15.31$, $p < .001$. Only the main effect of argument strength was significant in the low-involvement condition. Figures 2a and 2b clearly illustrate these findings.

Simple effects tests using planned contrasts gave the following results. Under high involvement, brand attitude was significantly higher for strong functional than for weak functional claims, $F(1, 212) = 21.38$, $p < .001$, whereas brand attitude did not significantly differ across argument quality levels for experiential claims, $F(1, 212) = .79$, *n.s.* Similarly, high-involvement participants' brand attitudes were significantly more favorable in response to strong functional than to strong experiential claims, $F(1, 212) = 7.33$, $p < .01$. These results were as predicted in H2.

Study 1 produced a significant interaction between claim type and involvement (see Figure 1). Argument quality was not manipulated in that study, however. The theoretical logic supports the analyses given above with reference to H2, but for descriptive purposes, we would also like to report that the three-way interaction can be interpreted as an interaction between involvement and claim type and the two levels of argument quality. Analyses showed a significant claim type $\times$ involvement interaction in the strong-arguments condition, precisely replicating the findings from Study 1,

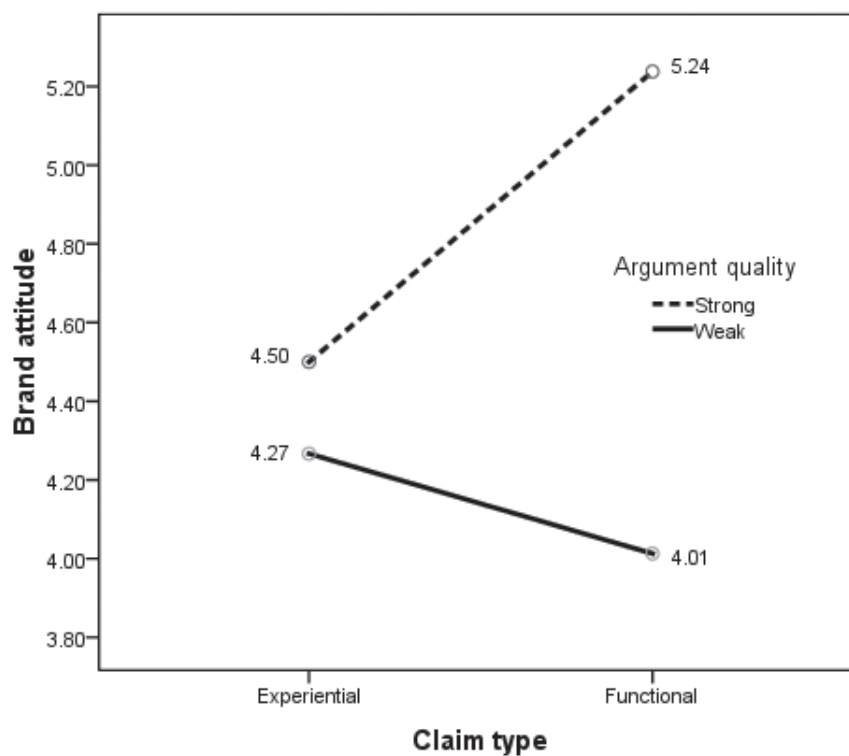
$F(1, 109) = 4.95$, $p < .05$, with the same patterns of means we obtained in Study 1, as can be observed in Figure 2c. There were no significant main or interaction effects in the weak-arguments condition.

Hypothesis 3 suggested that there should be more experience (functional)-oriented cognitive responses than functionally (experience)-oriented cognitive responses to experiential (functional) advertising claims. Participants' cognitive responses were coded into two categories: responses primarily related to one's own personal experiences and responses primarily related to the functional benefits of Bad Holzgau. Participants in the functional-claim condition had significantly more functional responses than did the participants in the experiential-claim condition, $M_{\text{functional responses, functional claims}} = .93$ versus $M_{\text{functional responses, experiential claims}} = .59$, $F(1, 218) = 7.81$, $p < .01$. Participants in the experiential-claim condition had significantly more experience responses than did participants in the functional-claim condition, $M_{\text{experience responses, experiential claims}} = 1.15$ versus $M_{\text{experience responses, functional claims}} = .81$, $F(1, 218) = 4.03$, $p < .05$. These results show that the types of cognitive responses given tended to reflect the content profile of the ad claims, lending support to our assumption that the different claim types trigger different memory structures giving rise to different interpretive frames. Looking at the average number of responses that could be classified into either of these two categories, functional-claim participants had $M = 1.737$, and experiential-claim participants had $M = 1.743$. So it could seem that it is not the amount of memory-related cognitive responses that differs between the two claim types, but rather the profile of the memory structure that the responses are reflecting. These results lend support to H3.

Hypothesis 4 suggested that there should be a higher total number of cognitive responses under high- than under low-involvement conditions. This is a straightforward prediction based on the ELM tradition (Petty and Cacioppo 1986). A 2 (argument quality: strong versus weak) $\times$ 2 (involvement: high versus low) $\times$ 2 (claim type: functional versus experiential)

FIGURE 2A

Study 2: Claim Type $\times$ Argument Quality Interaction on Brand Attitude Under High Involvement


FIGURE 2B

Study 2: Claim Type $\times$ Argument Quality Interaction on Brand Attitude Under Low Involvement

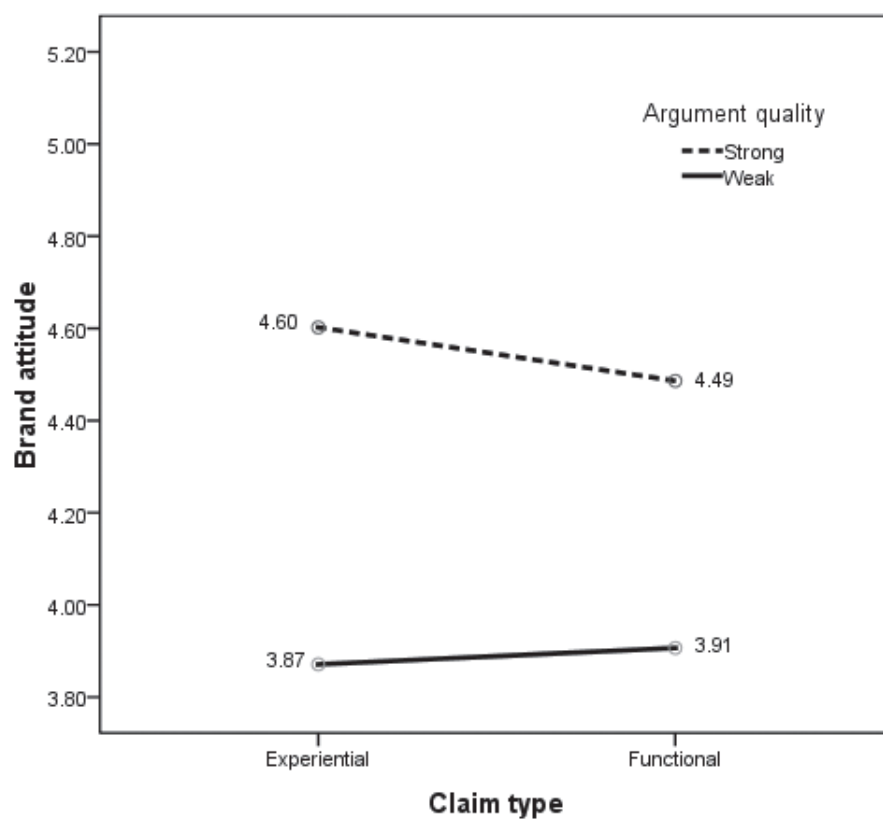
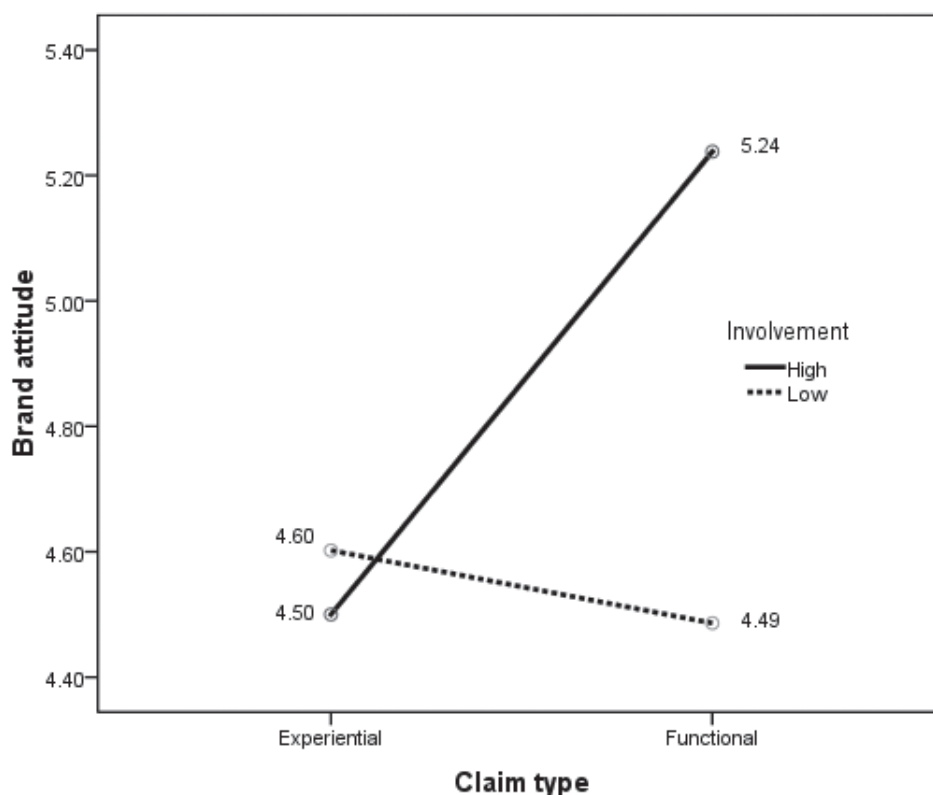


FIGURE 2C
Study 2: Claim Type $\times$ Involvement Interaction on Brand Attitude for Strong Arguments



between-subjects ANOVA on the total number of cognitive responses produced only a significant main effect of involvement where high-involvement participants generated more cognitive responses ($M = 4.47$) than did low-involvement participants ($M = 3.72$), $F(1, 194) = 4.49$, $p < .05$. No other effects approached significance.

Discussion

The purpose of Study 2 was to replicate Study 1's findings in a different context, explicitly control for or manipulate argument quality, and provide evidence for differences in cognitive responses between the two ad-claim types. The claim type by involvement interaction on brand attitude from Study 1 was replicated under the strong-arguments condition in Study 2. Of more theoretical interest, however, we found that the sensitivity to the argument quality manipulation was most pronounced under high involvement for the functional claims, in accordance with H2. Considering the insignificant main effect of claim type in Study 2, it seems logical to draw the conclusion that claim-type effects have to be considered in conjunction with the cogency of the message content as well as level of situational involvement. As personal relevance increases, Study 2 shows that participants are unable to differentiate between strong and weak arguments when framed as

promises of experiences, but are significantly more persuaded by strong functional claims. This finding could perhaps be thought of as a double-edged sword for functional claims; if proven strong, your new brand should be very well off; on the other hand, if your new brand is proven weak, you might be better off changing your claim profile. Seeing the experiential claim type as the safe choice and the functional claim as the risky choice, where risk has both upsides and downsides, might be tempting based on Study 2, but more research is warranted before drawing such a conclusion.

The pattern of cognitive responses supports our assumption that the two claim types trigger different types of memory. More references were made to one's own experiences (episodic memory) in response to experiential claims than in response to functional claims. With functional claims, more references were made to semantic (general facts, category knowledge) memory. This difference surfaced even though the different claims shared the same attributes of the new brand—only the framing differed, as predicted by H3. We also found that the sums of memory-related cognitive responses were equal across claim types, meaning that it is not necessarily the amount of memory ties that matter, but rather the content and reference points for the ties being made in response to different claims. Given the persuasive impact of the strong-argument version of the functional claim under high involvement, one could be

tempted to assume that the functional claim approach best serves the new brand entering into an already established category. More research is needed before such a conclusion can be drawn, however.

Finally, the pattern of cognitive responses in relation to the involvement manipulation supports the basic notion from the ELM (e.g., Petty and Cacioppo 1986), as we found the total number of cognitive responses to be primarily driven by level of situational involvement.

GENERAL DISCUSSION

The current research contributes to our understanding of how new entrants should advertise their offerings in established categories. The general implication of the current study is that if the new entrant has superior attributes and benefits compared with the competitors, managers should be advised to make use of this advantage instead of being tempted to give promises of future experiences as advocated by the experience economy literature (Pine and Gilmore 1998). Making use of this advantage is especially important in high-involvement situations.

The results of the two studies are consistent with our main prediction of an interaction between levels of involvement and the entrant's type of advertising claim. In general, we found a pattern of results showing that for a new entrant, a functional advertising claim outperformed an experiential claim in high-involvement conditions. To understand the reasons of these results, we manipulated argument quality and provided evidence for a higher degree of cognitive elaboration for functional ad claims proven by the higher sensitivity to argument quality for this claim type. On the other hand, intriguing in its own right is the lack of argument-quality sensitivity among highly involved participants exposed to experiential claims. Are experiential claims less susceptible to the importance of argument-quality variation—and could this lower susceptibility be attributed to the fact that episodic memory (the focus of experiential claims) renders an argument's cogency harder to assess? These questions could be important to address in future studies. If the merits of message arguments are evaluated based on semantic memory more than episodic memory, what does it mean in terms of the persuasive capacity of experiential claims with an episodic focus or emotional claims with a focus on nondeclarative, emotional memory (see, e.g., Percy and Elliot 2005, pp. 202–205)?

The current research may be helpful in understanding how new entrants in established categories should position and communicate their offerings initially or perhaps more important, in understanding the obstacles they face that limit their degree of freedom simply because they are new, unknown, and lack category credibility. Ad agencies frequently emphasize the importance of experiential advertisements and “good,

creative stories” that increase involvement and evoke consumers' feelings. This strategy might be important and relevant for incumbent brands, for which consumers have favorable affections and beliefs, but our findings indicate a different story for new entrants. When focusing on experiences in the category, advertisers will most likely prime category-specific associations and experiences, and consequently, prime existing category members. Hence, the persuasive potential of experiential advertisements will most likely benefit the established category members rather than the new entrant. On the other hand, if the new entrant advertises relevant functional benefits, the process of comparing functional benefits to the prototypical benefits of the category is much easier. If consumers actively think about the comparison and the result is in favor of the new entrant, the resulting evaluation will likely be positive. This study implies that if a new entrant possesses functional benefits superior to the competitors, and if these benefits are relevant to consumers, managers should make use of this advantage in their advertising, rather than being tempted to give promises about future experiences. In addition, if they can use tools and techniques to influence the personal relevance of the persuasive issue, managers should benefit from combining creative techniques to induce involvement with the advertising (e.g., sex, new formats) (e.g., MacInnis, Moorman, and Jaworski 1991; Putrevu 2008; Severn, Belch, and Belch 1990).

These two studies have some methodological shortcomings that should be addressed in future research to substantiate our findings. First, we have not experimentally manipulated, nor explicitly measured, the perceived diagnosticity of the two ad-claim types. Although the ad versions applied in the two studies were perceived as equally cogent in the strong-strong and weak-weak conditions, it could still be the case that they are perceived as different in diagnosticity. Consequently, future research could explicitly manipulate or measure diagnosticity. Second, we utilized only service categories in the current studies, thereby limiting the external validity of our findings. Despite our concern with internal validity in these two studies, future research would be well advised to employ a wider range of products and/or service categories.

In conclusion, when searching for the Holy Grail—a differentiated positioning in consumers' minds—managers of new brands should not discard the old and well-proven benefits-based advertising format. The alternative advertising strategy, using experiential advertising formats inspired by the experience economy literature, has yet to show its empirical supremacy.

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